CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

A LEADER LIKE NO OTHER

An Enduring Enigma

Some men and women are remembered for eras. Their stories are told, retold, read and discussed through generations.

Ratan is one such person, who will be spoken about for a long time to come—for the unique position he occupies in the economic and social history of the country, and for his values and ethical standards that are ahead of his time. He will be celebrated as a pioneering industrialist who took India to the world, upholding foundational values that were considered too utopian to succeed, and for according equal if not more importance to societal welfare.

As an industrialist who has played a significant role in the economic progress of the country and society, amongst the later industrial leaders, Ratan can perhaps be compared only to J.R.D. Tata. Commenting on the contributions of JRD and Ratan, Azim Premji, who is known for his philanthropic activities as well, remarks, 'Both were leaders for their times. JRD was the builder of the Tata Group, and Ratan has been its modernizer. JRD nurtured the roots, Ratan has integrated the vast plantation.'

Ratan triumphed against all odds and did so spectacularly. He gave the House of Tatas a storeyed history. The 'business group that bears his name has transformed itself from an Indian giant into a global powerhouse … [Ratan] is a titan … the most powerful businessman in India and one of the most influential in the world', wrote *The Economist*. He built businesses first to fulfil the nation's goals and second, to generate profits. '[For Ratan] the social importance [of a decision] to India as a nation would override a business decision, in my judgement,' says Maurice Greenberg. He would